golden idol temple of Ma'bar,' wrote Malik Kafur's contemporary, the historian Zia-ud-Din Barni, 'and the golden idols which for centuries had been worshipped by the Hindus of that country. The fragments of the golden temple, and the broken idols of gold and gilt became the rich spoils of the army.'[7]

The final tally of gold bullion removed under Sultan Alaud-Din's orders from the South amounted to 96,000 maunds in weight, which could be anywhere between 1000 and 6900 tonnes. When paraded in triumph through the streets of Delhi, along with 612 captured elephants and twenty thousand horses, this booty created such a sensation that it passed into folklore within the Muslim world, eventually to be transformed by way of the *Arabian Nights* into Aladdin's Cave.

From time to time tangible evidence of Ala-ud-Din's impact on the South continues to come to light as farmers and construction workers stumble upon carefully buried temple deities, as happened in August 1987 when workmen renovating the temple of Tiruramanathesvara in Esalam village in South Arcot District, inland from Pondicherry, came across four layers of buried metal objects. These included a copper plate charter issued to the temple by the Chola king Rajendra in 1036, several bells, some ritual tripods and twenty-three bronzes of a variety of Shaiva deities, all of which had been carefully laid face down within a brick pit and covered with sand. The fact that they were not recovered soon after their burial would suggest that no one involved had lived to reveal the secret of their whereabouts.

The first Arab invader who led an army into Sind in 712 brought with him his own historians, who set down written accounts of his triumphs over the unbelievers and idolators in gloating detail. That pattern was followed by the many Muslim warlords who followed him into India. These